

FULL CIRCLE

At a time when Indian men's football is enduring a barren spell, the women's team carved out a historic milestone, qualifying for the Women's AFC Asian Cup on merit for the first time.

The achievement carried added weight given what had unfolded in 2022. Host of the tournament, India was forced to withdraw after just one match, a goalless draw against Iran, following a COVID-19 outbreak in the squad. What was meant to be a moment of arrival ended in heartbreak.



Three years on, the response was emphatic. India produced a stirring 2-1 comeback win over Thailand in a must-win group-stage match to seal qualification for the 2026 Asian Cup.

The night belonged to Sangita Basfore. Sidelined with an ACL injury in 2022, she returned to score both goals. India struck first in the 29th minute through Sangita, only for Chatchawan Rodthong to equalise shortly after halftime and tilt the momentum Thailand's way.

As qualification began to slip, India found resolve. In the 74th minute, Shilky Devi Hemam's delivery found Sangita, who headed past Tiffany Sornpao to restore the lead.

The final whistle ended Thailand's uninterrupted Asian Cup run since 1997, and signalled a defining new chapter for Indian women's football.

THE OLD, THE NEW

The rivalry between the youngest world champion, D. Gukesh, and Magnus Carlsen took a decisive turn in 2025, when the prodigy finally toppled the sport's modern standard-bearer.

The moment came in the sixth round of Norway Chess. Gukesh defeated Carlsen to record his first classical win over the world No. 1, triggering an uncharacteristic eruption from the Norwegian. Carlsen slammed his fist on the table, scattering the pieces, and stormed out. The clip ricocheted across the internet, turning Carlsen into a meme and Gukesh into the game's newest symbol of arrival.

Viswanathan Anand offered context rather than condemnation. Speaking to PTI, he suggested the loss cut deep, with Carlsen keen to "draw a line in the sand" against the next generation. A clean sweep against Gukesh, Anand said, would have mattered greatly.

A month later, the pattern repeated, though the reaction did not. At the Super United Rapid and Blitz in Zagreb, Gukesh beat Carlsen again, this time with the black pieces, controlling the game for 49 moves.

Two wins. Two formats. And a rivalry unmistakably entering a new phase.

